

Though Sandi's father was a very successful trial attorney, her parents didn't consciously indulge her. They simply included her in their upscale lifestyle that meant a new wardrobe each year, a new car every other year, and winter vacations in Colorado.

She knew other people didn't have as much as her parents, because she had several close friends who came from middle-income families. But she also experienced strife in her own family because her mother and father argued frequently. Usually their arguments revolved around her father's commitment to his work and the fact that he was rarely around. Many times Sandi, her mother, and one of Sandi's friends spent those holiday trips to Aspen or Vail without Sandi's father. He rarely accompanied them. By the time Sandi was a senior in high school, her parents were separated. The separation later became semipermanent, although there was never a divorce. Her mother did not cope well.

In college, Sandi's life was radically changed through a campus ministry. She was invited to a meeting and agreed to go because she already considered herself a Christian. At that meeting she came face-to-face with the reality that she was a churchgoer, but not a Christian, and she accepted Christ.

At a later meeting she met Bud, fell in love with him, and married him within the year. As is so often the case, although Sandi was not the least bit embarrassed by her new husband's humble background, he was. Visiting her home was agony for Bud; it made him feel inadequate. Nothing she could say would convince him that all was not bliss in that beautiful home. His goal was set: eventually he would have the same kind of home.

I share this background to show that when someone gets into debt from seeking a "comfortable" lifestyle, it is often the result of decisions clouded by good intentions and rationalizations. I believe that one of the worst things that can happen to people is achieving their financial goals. Then they are able to surround themselves with enough "things" and consider themselves to have achieved a measure of happiness.